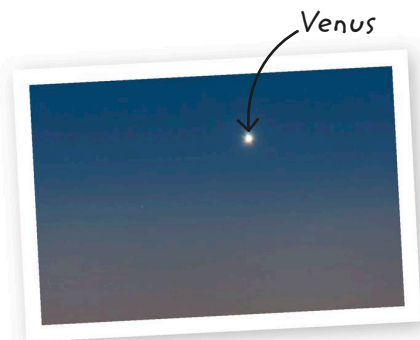
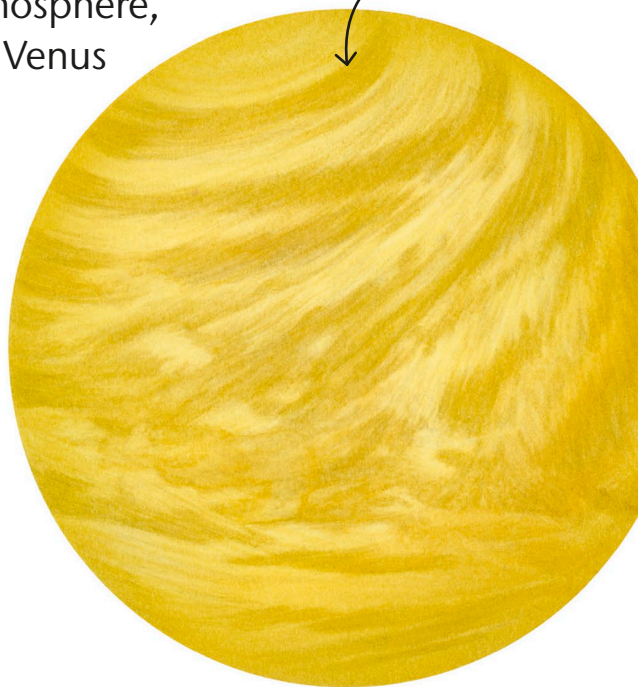


Mercury and Venus

The two closest planets to the Sun, Mercury and Venus, are both rocky planets, but visitors would find them very different from each other. Mercury is an almost airless world with no atmosphere, or layer of gas around it. Venus is surrounded by a very thick layer of clouds.

Venus's clouds prevent us from seeing its rocky surface.



Bright planet

Venus shines brightly because the clouds that surround it reflect sunlight well. Venus often looks like a very bright star in Earth's sky just before sunrise and just after sunset. Because of this, it is known as the morning or evening star.

Not for humans

Venus is not a friendly place for humans to visit. If you stepped onto its surface, the hot temperature would bake you, the acid in the clouds would poison you, and the high pressure of the atmosphere would crush you.